

Exodus 18:1-12

The Confession of a Gentile

Introduction:

"Family Reunion"—Jethro together with his daughter and grandchildren (Moses's wife and children) reunite with Moses in the wilderness...

So what? Why recount this "reunion" at all?

The narrator has up until now been very selective in what he includes in his narrative— and with a view toward quickly bringing the story from the victory at the Red Sea to the formation of Israel as a new nation at Sinai—one could see why the author would include, say the amazing battle with the Amalekites in so far as it introduced both the prophetic and priestly roles of Joshua and Aaron respectively in anticipation of the Mosaic Covenant... but a family reunion? What possible significance could this have for the future? What does this anticipate such as to have significance for the life of Israel? Isn't this but a personal thing between Moses and his wife, kids and father in law?

Think again!

Exposition:

How Moses's wife and kids got with Jethro in the first place we don't know, even as it is clear that the narrator has no interest.

What we do know is that before the Exodus as noted in 4:20 Moses took his whole family to Egypt after leaving Midian in response to God's call to free Israel from Egypt. E.g. Nothing else is said until now, where Zipporah and kids are with Jethro... perhaps Moses sent them away before the plagues as to protect his family—but this would seem to suggest that Moses didn't trust God to protect Israel and his family... or perhaps she was sent away after the Israelites were delivered into Egypt, or perhaps after during the Amalekite battle... we don't know...

Nor is any attention given to the sorts of things that one would expect about a family reunion—such as the catching up and expressions of joy, etc...

Rather, this whole episode regarding this otherwise personal family reunion quickly focuses on two things—both as relate to Jethro especially!

First, 1-12, there is Jethro's reaction to hearing the news about God's mighty acts to save Israel—most especially his "confession." (this week)

Second, there is Jethro's reaction to observing Moses's pastoral work load, and most especially his recommendation for a division of labor (12-27) (next week)

As we will see, both are included in the narrative as they both anticipate significant issues as per the mission and polity of future Israel!

Today: Significance of Jethro's confession

I. Jethro is a "Gentile"

Notice vs. 1 especially—Jethro "the midianite priest"

Before we skip over this—consider what this would have evoked in the minds of those hearing this narrative read in the congregation...

E.g. it is not just Jethro—Moses father in law—but Jethro—“the medianite priest!”

What would this mean to the future people hearing this read in the congregation?

E.g. To be sure, Midian the nation and Medianites the people WOULD NOT evoke happy thoughts in the Israel congregation...

In fact, this may be the only time that the Medianites have a positive encounter with Israel!

Historically:

AS descendants of Abraham (gen.25:2) the Medianites are first encountered as the merchants who sell Joseph to Potiphar (37:28, 36)... e.g. if you wanted to despise some group for getting them into the mess with Egypt—you could just as well start with the Medianites...

Futuristically:

And perhaps more importantly, the Medianites are over and over again shown to be hostile to Israel as a nation... for instance, it was their leaders, that joined with the Moabites, serving as Balak’s messengers who lure Balaam to curse Israel by promise of financial gain in Num.22:7ff... Their opposition escalates in Num.25 when the marriage of the Israelite “Zimri” with a Medianite (Cozbi) prompts Phinehas to kill them both... not exactly a family reunion sort of encounter! (or perhaps it is depending on your point of view ☺)

More specifically, Num. 25:17 summarizes well the way Israel felt about the Midianites when Israel is commanded

“Treat the Midianites as enemies and kill them.”

Later on, the Medianites are mentioned again in Joshua 13:21.. and then in Judges 6-7 where they are Israel’s enemies and as then defeated by Gideon!

Finally, in Isaiah 10:26, Israel’s attitude toward the Midianites is well noted when it is said:

” The Lord Almighty will lash them with a whip, as when he struck down Midian at the rock of Oreb, and he will raise his staff over the waters, as he did with Egypt.”

e.g. Egypt, Medianites—all the same—enemies of Israel and **outsiders to the covenant!**

In short, whatever is about to happen in our text, it is about a “medianite”, a “Gentile”, a stranger and alien to the house of Israel, even considered as hostile to the covenant!

Illus: He would have felt like a “mangy dog” in their midst (even as this was a common metaphor for Gentiles later)

Clinton’s story about dogs in the city... Like the dogs who encountered dancing kids in the city...

So in light of this brief survey—what would clearly have stuck out to the future recipient of this narrative in Israel is that

- a) Mose’s wife was a Medianite, his children were half Medianite...
- b) This particular Medianite is here making a “confession”! (vs. 10)

II. Jethro’s Confession:

I say “confession” here quite intentionally, as to refer to an act of personal faith!

Because:

1. vs. 11—"now I know" this is standard confessional language in Exodus (vs. 6:7, 7:5, 8:10, 9:29) , as related to making a personal confession of faith!

2. vs. 10-12—Doxology which is clearly meant to distinguish his new found faith with his earlier faith... E.g as a "priest" of Median- he no doubt would have represented "other so called gods" but here...

"Yaweh is greater than all other gods..."

"Blessed be the LORD, who has delivered you from the Egyptians and from Pharaoh. 11 Now I know that the LORD is greater than all gods, because he delivered the people from the Egyptians, when they dealt arrogantly with them."

3. In Context: Think about this for a minute-- Even when repeatedly Israel loses sight of its confession and shows a reluctant heart, slow to confess and believe even after all that God has done and said to them.. here is Jethro, the Gentile priest, who seemingly gets it!

The Medianite, not the Israelites, has learned the lesson of the Exodus, namely, that Yaweh is greater than all other so called gods!

4. Now all of this makes sense then of what is described earlier in vs. 2-4—where specially attention is given to the names of the grandsons that Jethro reunites with their father... Names are often mentioned in the ANE as for their symbolic meaning relative to the purpose of God...

In this case—both names are concrete reminders to the readers of where Moses and the Israelites have been relative to God's purpose...

e.g.

1. Gershom—which draws attention to the fact that Moses was a foreigner in Midian quoting from

Ex. 2:22 She bore a son, and he named him Gershom; for he said, "I have been an alien residing in a foreign land."

2. Eliezer- which draws attention to the fact that God the deliverer/helper as derived from the Heb. "helper/deliver" ...

In other words—Jethro—brings two ideas together as symbolized in this reunion of Moses to his sons—how it is that a foreigner is also confessing faith in Yaweh as the greatest of all so called gods, even as revealed in his salvation of Israel from Egypt!

And isn't this what the book of Exodus is all about, even as this would be the ultimate purpose of the Exodus itself!

Jethro's confession is reminiscent of the corporate confession of Israel in the song by the sea..

Ex. 15:11 "Who is like you, O LORD, among the gods? Who is like you, majestic in holiness, awesome in splendor, doing wonders? 12 You stretched out your right hand, the earth swallowed them. 13 "In your steadfast love you led the people whom you redeemed; you guided them by your strength to **your holy abode**."

It's to this purpose, that God would be proclaimed as the true and living God, greater than all other so called gods, that we are told over and over again was the ultimate motivation of God's saving activity! As in Chapter 3—where the whole of the Exodus is framed as the context whereby God's name "Yaweh" is revealed for the sake of Israel and yes, all the nations.

E.g. Jethro, the Medianite got it... the purpose of the Exodus is fulfilled even as God said in **Ex.9:16** that his dealings with Pharaoh were so that
"my name might be proclaimed in ALL the earth."

NOTE THEN: The Hebrew word used for "proclaim" in 9:16 is the same word that is used in vs. 8 of our passage translated "told" in the NIV... E.g. it is to a Medianite that Moses "proclaims" the name of Yahweh, even as it is a Medianite of all people that responds in "faith."

5. And so, the final and climatic evidence that Jethro's statement is in fact a confession of faith is made sure by what happens next... .. in vs. 12...

12 And Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, brought a burnt offering and sacrifices to God; and Aaron came with all the elders of Israel to eat bread with Moses' father-in-law in the presence of God.

E.g., burnt offerings and sacrifices are OT sacraments, even as here it done in the "presence of God" According to vs. 7, it is presumably taking place in "the tent"—perhaps a reference to the portable "tent of meeting with God" as then a looking forward to the tabernacle in chapters 25-40 in so far as it represented the supreme cultic center, not less so than say the Lord's table that is in our midst today!

No stronger language could be used to indicate that Jethro, the Medianite, is a child of God, no longer a stranger and alien to the covenant, but a member of the household of God in the OT!

What is even more significant perhaps is that while this was the stated purpose given to Pharaoh for why Israel needed to leave Egypt in the first place, this is the first time it is explicitly references, even if not the first time that a sacrifice was made as per the "altar" last week.

Again, what an amazing turn of events that a "Gentile" is partaking of the sacraments with Moses in response to the God's deliverance of Israel from Egypt!

This IS THE POINT!

This is especially interesting in light of Dt. 23:3:

Deut. 23:3

No Ammonite or Moabite shall be admitted to the assembly of the LORD. Even to the tenth generation, none of their descendants shall be admitted to the assembly of the LORD,

What does this mean—except that in so far as Ammonites and Moabites represented "unbelievers" they are not to be admitted... and yet, we have here an instance where God's mission relative to Israel is ultimate meant to attract unbelievers into belief!

Israel was, first and foremost a people chosen to worship God, and secondly a people chosen as an instrument to proclaim the glory of Yahweh to the rest of the world!

III. Redemptive History: God's Desire for the Nations.. and the purpose of his redemptive activity!

E.g this is not a new idea!!!

The nations were always on God's mind—as for instance in Genesis 17:5-6...

Gen. 17:5

No longer shall your name be Abram, but your name shall be Abraham; for I have made you the ancestor of a multitude of nations. **6** I will make you exceedingly fruitful; and I will make nations of you, and kings shall come from you.

Perhaps hints to this happening in Exodus... is the confession of Pharaoh's officials in 10:7 and then later in reference to those who joined Israel out of Egypt it is said...

Ex. 12:38

A mixed crowd also went up with them, and livestock in great numbers, both flocks and herds.

Even clearer still in Ruth who of all things was a Moabite.. even the ancestor of King David and ultimate the messiah Jesus Christ!

And then we think of Isaiah... and especially Isaiah 19 when Isaiah sees a time when even Egypt will come to know God...

AS we come then into the NC—of course this is in full view...

So then also...

Matt. 12:18

“Here is my servant, whom I have chosen,
my beloved, with whom my soul is well pleased.
I will put my Spirit upon him,
and he will proclaim justice to the Gentiles.
19 He will not wrangle or cry aloud,
nor will anyone hear his voice in the streets.
20 He will not break a bruised reed
or quench a smoldering wick
until he brings justice to victory.
21 And in his name the Gentiles will hope.”

Great commission

19 Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, **20** and teaching them to obey everything that I have commanded you. And remember, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

Pentecost

Acts 2:5

Now there were devout Jews from every nation under heaven living in Jerusalem. **6** And at this sound the crowd gathered and was bewildered, because each one heard them speaking in the native language of each. **7** Amazed and astonished, they asked, “Are not all these who are speaking Galileans? **8** And how is it that we hear, each of us, in our own native language? **9** Parthians, Medes, Elamites, and residents of Mesopotamia, Judea and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia, **10** Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya belonging to Cyrene, and visitors from Rome, both Jews and proselytes, **11** Cretans and Arabs—in our own languages we hear them speaking about God’s deeds of power.”

Roman 11:

Rom. 11:13

Now I am speaking to you Gentiles. Inasmuch then as I am an apostle to the Gentiles, I glorify my ministry **14** in order to make my own people jealous, and thus save some of them. **15** For if their rejection is the reconciliation of the world, what will their acceptance be but life from the dead! **16** If the part of the dough offered as first fruits is holy, then the whole batch is holy; and if the root is holy, then the branches also are holy.

Rom. 11:17

But if some of the branches were broken off, and you, a wild olive shoot, were grafted in their place to share the rich root of the olive tree,

E.g. Paul point is not that the Nations are “separate but equal” in status relative to God, but that the nations are to be grafted into the covenant community by faith so as then to mean that in Christ, there is therefore no distinction!

Romans 15

5 May the God of steadfastness and encouragement grant you to live in harmony with one another, in accordance with Christ Jesus, 6 so that together you may with one voice glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.

Rom. 15:7

Welcome one another, therefore, just as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God. 8 For I tell you that Christ has become a servant of the circumcised on behalf of the truth of God in order that he might confirm the promises given to the patriarchs, 9 and in order that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy. As it is written,

“Therefore I will confess you among the Gentiles,
and sing praises to your name”;

10 and again he says,

“Rejoice, O Gentiles, with his people”;

11 and again,

“Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles,
and let all the peoples praise him”;

12 and again Isaiah says,

“The root of Jesse shall come,
the one who rises to rule the Gentiles;
in him the Gentiles shall hope.”

13 May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that you may abound in hope by the power of the Holy Spirit.

Eph. 2...

Eph. 2:11

So then, remember that at one time you Gentiles by birth, called “the uncircumcision” by those who are called “the circumcision”—a physical circumcision made in the flesh by human hands— 12 remember that you were at that time without Christ, being aliens from the commonwealth of Israel, and strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in the world. 13 But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. 14 For he is our peace; in his flesh he has made both groups into one and has broken down the dividing wall, that is, the hostility between us. 15 He has abolished the law with its commandments and ordinances, that he might create in himself one new humanity in place of the two, thus making peace, 16 and might reconcile both groups to God in one body through the cross, thus putting to death that hostility through it. 17 So he came and proclaimed peace to you who were far off and peace to those who were near; 18 for through him both of us have access in one Spirit to the Father. 19 So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are citizens with the saints and also members of the household of God, 20 built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself as the cornerstone. 21 In him the whole structure is joined together and grows into a holy temple in the Lord; 22 in whom you also are built together spiritually into a dwelling place for God.

Finally, Rev.

Rev. 5:9

They sing a new song:

“You are worthy to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slaughtered and by your blood you ransomed for God saints from every tribe and language and people and nation;

Rev. 7:9

After this I looked, and there was a great multitude that no one could count, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, robed in white, with palm branches in their hands.

Rev. 14:6

Then I saw another angel flying in midheaven, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who live on the earth—to every nation and tribe and language and people.

Rev. 15:4

Lord, who will not fear

and glorify your name?
For you alone are holy.
All nations will come
and worship before you,
for your judgments have been revealed.”

So what does all this mean for us today?

Evidently, God is very concerned that Israel knew, and that we now know, his intentions relative to his salvation succ as to be “FOR THE OUTSIDERS” AS MUCH AS FOR THOSE WHOA RE ALREADY INSIDERS...

Who is the Medianite today?

I think of Linda...,,.

Illustration: A “Midianite” named Linda... her experience of God’s rejection through one sort of Christian, even her Christian father, later to discover God’s welcome through other sorts of Christians...

Story goes like this...

(From , “Hooked on Heroin, Healed by Love,” By Alice Lawson Cox)

In January 1987—Seventeen-year-old Linda smoothed the wrinkles on her jeans and walked onto the dance floor... She danced and drank with her friends until the night’s revelry was suddenly interrupted: Someone turned up the lights. Linda gasped as her father strode into the room and dragged her away. **Once home he raged, “If God were to return right now, what would He think?”**

(message—He would condemn you, he would reject you!!!)

Linda’s experience of Christianity was that it rejected sinners, not welcome them...

Concerning the shame she grew up with in her Christian home and church-- “I never felt good enough or right enough for my father,” recalls the petite brunette, tears in her brown eyes. “I wanted to feel that I was special to him, but I never felt accepted.”

Feelings of inadequacy and unloveliness drove Linda farther from her parents and their God. She later discovered how **“The drug culture accepted me where I was,” she says. “Taking drugs was an entrée into ‘the crowd.’”**

By age 24 Linda was living with a drug dealer and addicted to the hero-making drug he pushed. “It was the only secure life I knew,” says Linda. She was soon arrested for selling and distributing heroin. Sitting in the isolation unit at a Correctional Institution for Women, the frail young Linda felt even more unlovable. She had failed everyone. For the first time, Linda realized her helplessness, her inability to escape the mess she had made of her life.

Uncertain whether she would even be heard, Linda asked God for forgiveness. Then she begged Him for even more: I’ve got to know Your love!” (looking then for acceptance... Linda asked a friend to send her a Bible she could she later noted how “I knew all the judgment and laws,” she says, “but I didn’t know about His grace and love.”

Over time and while in jail, God healed her of her drug addictions, and through the love and acceptance of some correctional officers, began to feel something of the genuine grace and acceptance of God!!! Her incarceration became a time of drawing closer to God. Other inmates began to ask about the changes they saw in her. Although she knew God was changing her, the healing process was slow.

This is where you would expect me to end the story, right—but my point is yet to be made actually... for at The root of Linda’s drug dependency was low self-esteem and feelings of rejection... Years of trying to earn love, yet not living up to others’ ideals, were hard to erase. She needed the affirmation of people around her. **what would happen when she left the security and acceptance of the prison..**

As Linda's parole date drew near, the churchgoers who led a Bible study at the women's prison reinforced her feelings of rejection. They only helped people in prison; she'd have to make it on her own in the "real world."

Once released, Linda tried to join a church but she soon discovered that the members wanted only to preach at her and "lay hands" on her, self-righteously praying away her problems. No one ever said, "Want to go to lunch?" Without Christian fellowship and acceptance, the crisis of adjustment was overpowering. "It was worse than prison, because my last source of security was gone. I knew that I was alone, "

All alone in her apartment, Linda stared through tears at the dingy walls. Everything seemed distorted and far away. Her body numb, she staggered to the medicine cabinet—then to the refrigerator. "The pain is not worth it," she thought, downing several pills with a glass of wine. The next thing that she realized was waking up in a hospital..

Think about this, What God could do through a prison, Christians were undoing in church!!!!

When Linda awoke in a hospital, things seemed clearer to Linda than ever before.. God's love—and God's love only—had seen her through. Thanking God for sparing her life, she told Him, "I have nowhere else to go but You." **Filled with new hope, Linda began attending a Bible study with other kind so Christians... all ex-offenders—like one of the family, and she thrived under their loving care.** The leaders, John and Alex demonstrated a new concept to Linda. Like her heavenly Father, they proved their love to her over and over again. In response to their love, Linda learned to love her parents. "I learned to look at my parents with God's eyes," says Linda, "and to accept them as He accepted me."

E.g. the convict, having felt the acceptance of God through God's community, learned to accept those who rejected her in God's name!

"God became my Resource, my Encourager, and my Husband. She was only then ready for marriage, where she didn't need a husband to be accepted, but could from a position of being accepted, free from the fear of condemnation, she was able to love another!!!

Referring to the life she once knew, Linda says, "People who are hurting only know worldly ways to lick wounds (rejection and condemnation) But no one can heal them like Jesus."

Application:

1. Relevance to the Christian

We can and should be more bold...

We as a church should be less hostile and less alienated from the world..

Paul said he was willing to suffer all things for the sake of the elect—and for Paul the elect were both believing and unbelieving...

Therefore,

Knowing there were "elect" unbelievers—he was more bold—knowing that there are some chosen to believe if only they will have a messenger...

Romans 10—how will they believe...

2. Relevance to the Church

We can and should be more accepting and welcoming!

The church ought then to assume the posture that Israel was supposed to assume—one that understands that our salvation is not an end, but a means to a greater ends—namely, for the evangelization of the world, to the praise of God's glorious power and grace as the only true and living God!

Warp and Woof of true orthodoxy...

To often, we can forget this—thinking that the end is us and our salvation.. To be sure, God's love is true and he does love us, and yet just as God is greater than us, so too, there is a greater purpose to our salvation as then per the greater ends of glorifying God..

E.g. it is an aspect of true orthodoxy—that not only are we concerned to “get it right” in terms of the doctrines and laws concerning God—but we must get it right in terms of Gods’ mission as well as to bring the elect from every nations into confession of faith so that it can rightly be proclaims” God is greater than all other gods!!!

... Are there any Midianite's among us... ? ...

(So we should consider—who will the “nations” look like in their pagan and worldly estates...

Are we “hospitable” to them as Romans exhorts..

Consider for a moment who are the “nations” from a spiritual point of view... the “nations” are no longer “nation-states” or ethnic groups—at least I sure hope not—(although we need to continue to work on being more vernacular sensitive such as to bring the gospel and worship to the world in their own vernacular!)

But rather, the group of people most synonymous to the Midianites to Israel are “unbelievers” A good description of what a Midianite is for us today can be found in 1Cor. 4 sexually immoral or greedy, or is an idolater, reviler, drunkard, or robber.

And yet, notice carefully, Paul says we are NOT to NOT associate with them (disassociate)..

1Cor. 5:9

I wrote to you in my letter not to associate with sexually immoral persons— 10 not at all meaning the immoral of this world, or the greedy and robbers, or idolaters, since you would then need to go out of the world. 11 But now I am writing to you not to associate with anyone who bears the name of brother or sister who is sexually immoral or greedy, or is an idolater, reviler, drunkard, or robber. Do not even eat with such a one. 12 For what have I to do with judging those outside? Is it not those who are inside that you are to judge? 13 God will judge those outside. “Drive out the wicked person from among you.”

And yet Within the church, for the sake of God's glory, we are to discipline those who are acting like “Midianites” (pagans)—and yet even this is with a view toward winning them to Christ, not losing them!

4 When you are assembled, and my spirit is present with the power of our Lord Jesus, 5 you are to hand this man over to Satan for the destruction of the flesh, so that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord.

The confusion is long standing—both in Israel of the OC, and sadly even today in the new Israel of the NC—the confusion is this—that for the sake of God's glory, we should not associate with unbelievers, and in effect keep them at bay! Confusing then church discipline for the glory of God, with then treating the would be Midianites (worldly) away from us as persons and as a church.

Don't confuse the need to have church discipline in order to glorify God and reclaim persons to him, with then being against sinners or as if to alienate the world from us..

Paul's command "do not associate with them" in 1Cor pertains to membership and communion, NOT evangelism and genuine love and mercy for them!

So for example:

1. Parents—we rightly want to protect our children from sinful activity because a) we know that it would glorify God for God to sanctify our children and b) because it would benefit our children since sin is harmful to our ultimate health and happiness. BUT then we say—don't hang out with sinners, or we isolate them from sinners—this would be a mistake.. at least up until such time as our being with sinners means binding ourselves emotionally or even legally as in marriage to them and their idols so to speak..
2. Church members—if we are doing our job—we will one and at the same time—love those who are greedy, sexually promiscuous, robbers, into our midst—even as we seek to introduce them to the salvation of God . in the NC sense, the ultimate Exodus is accomplished by the death and resurrection of Christ... we proclaim this to the world, even as Moses proclaimed it to his father in law—showing them acceptance and hope rather than condemnation..

We Be rid of the "double standard"

E.g. accepting our "sins" while condemning the world for their sins... e.g.

Why is say "homosexuality" so much worse than say greed and selfishness such as to produce deadly poverty around the world... why is the so called "clean" sins like lying and cheating and backbiting worse than say "drug addiction"...

I'm reminded of the conversation two mangy dogs had upon seeing two city kids dancing wildly in the park.. One mangy dog to another says: How come they can move and shuffle around like that, and they pay them for it, and if we move and shuffle around like that, they de-worm us!

Too often, we have a double standard relative to the law and sin—

James says that if you fail at one part of the law, we fail at all of it! After then applied to the sins of the rich (greed, slander, etc) vs. the sins of the poor (stealing, etc) James says...

James 2:8

You do well if you really fulfill the royal law according to the scripture, "You shall love your neighbor as yourself." **9** But if you show partiality, you commit sin and are convicted by the law as transgressors.

10 For whoever keeps the whole law but fails in one point has become accountable for all of it. **11** For the one who said, "You shall not commit adultery," also said, "You shall not murder." Now if you do not commit adultery but if you murder, you have become a transgressor of the law. **12** So speak and so act as those who are to be judged by the law of liberty. **13** For judgment will be without mercy to anyone who has shown no mercy; mercy triumphs over judgment.

Here's the point—we often make our churches unwelcome to those who sin in ways different than us... e.g. there are certain kinds of lifestyles and sins that we easily categorized as "medianite" kinds of sins by way of analogy to Israel.. we may do this consciously or unconsciously in our groups and fellowship tables..

For instance, if a person comes to your small group and confesses his/her struggle with drugs, or perhaps sexual addiction expressed through homosexuality and/or prostitution— what would happen?

Gasp—surprise, isolation from our children????

But what if a person confesses their struggle against materialism as per selfishly hoarding resources to themselves in spite of the people they know that could be helped by these resources in some fundamental ways...

3. Relevance to the "medianite" who is among us!

Are there any Midianites among us?

E.g. someone who thinks of themselves as somehow “outside” of the Christian world/culture/faith even?

Someone who thinks they have believed things, done things, thought things—that would disqualify you from God’s promises and people!

Good news, God loves Midianites—even as hearing about the great miracle of God to save his people not only from Egypt but from condemnation, sin and even death itself could move you to “confess” faith in the God of Israel and New Israel...